



Just a Phone

The 'Small is beautiful' philosophy works just fine in the world of Mobile devices. Compactness is now a necessity, not a luxury. Mobile phones have shrunk over the years, and are now smaller than a pack of cigarettes, and packed with features that were previously unheard of.

Looks have also transformed, from the first cell phone—the Motorola DynaTAC 8000X, which weighed 870 grams and was almost a foot long—to the tiny marvels of today. The more you pay, the more a phone can do for you, however in this section, we look at today's vanilla phones, which perform the basic function of a mobile phone and don't cost the earth.

Design and style

The design and style of a phone, plays a vital role in the buying decision. The keys should be designed for typing long messages easily, but also gel with the design of the phone. Phones such as the Sony Ericsson T100, and the latest Nokia 2100 and 3610 stand out in the crowd, because of a complete new design and good grip. The Alcatel One Touch 311, was too thick with a smooth body that impeded grip. The Motorola C300, on the other hand, had a firm grip thanks to the small form factor and the finish of its body.

As for usability, many phones—ranging from the older Nokia 3310, to the latest Nokia 3610—have a 2-way navigation key that comes handy while scrolling through a long list of names or messages. The Alcatel One Touch 311 has a two-way navigation key, which is better than other phones. It is akin to the scroll wheel of a computer mouse, which can be used to scroll up and down, and also as a button. However, the button has to be pressed hard, which is taxing if you're in a hurry to get to some menu option.

Many people complain about the number of key presses it takes to reach a function within a menu. Therefore, we checked the ease of use of the interface by performing commonly used tasks, such as writing new messages or changing ring tones. The Nokia phones were simple to use. Sony Ericsson, on the other hand takes some getting

used to. Once you spend 10 or 15 minutes with the user manual, everything falls into place. Both the Sony Ericsson T100 and T200, have the same interface, but the T200 has a 4-way button, which provides easier access to settings. Sony Ericsson and Motorola are the only phones to have shortcut customisation—you can assign the same key combination to your new phone as your old phone. Nokia on the other hand, has the old system of keying in digit combinations to access different menus, which calls for good user memory.

If ease of use is a must, and design is high on your list, consider the Sony Ericsson T100.



Motorola C300
Rating: **B-**
Price: Rs 6,695

Basic phone features

Once you have checked out the look and feel of the phone, and browsed through its menu, the next important consideration is battery life and weight. A phone should not compromise on weight, with build quality, as impacts can leave the phone useless if the internal electronics or the LCD screen is damaged. As far as build quality goes, the Nokia phones are the most sturdy phones in the market, especially the 33xx series. The Sony Ericsson phones, especially the T100, were not far behind. This phone weighs only 75 grams, has a good build quality and low price, making it a good buy.



Nokia 3350
Rating: **B**
Price: Rs 6,499

Battery life

The battery life is one of the most critical features of a cell phone. The phone with the maximum battery power, was the Nokia 3350, which was blessed with an 850 mAh Li-Ion battery that can last as long as 4 hours and 45 minutes. This time will come down if you use other features such as sending or receiving messages, composing tones or editing pictures.

The Alcatel 311, has a rated talk time of 5 hours and 30 minutes. In real world conditions, where signal strengths and temperatures fluctuate, this time will reduce to about 3 hours. This was also the only phone to have a Ni-Mh (700 mAh) battery, which looked like three AAA batteries, enclosed in a feeble plastic case.

All the phones were Dual band, and if you plan on roaming abroad, only the Sony Ericsson T200, with Tri-band support is a viable option. This phone also sports WAP and GPRS.

Sony Ericsson has introduced a serious contender—the T200—to Nokia phones in terms of basic features, such as weight, network support, price, and looks.



Nokia 3315
Rating: **B**
Price: Rs 5,399

Memory

The in-built memory of a cell phone not only helps you store more contacts, but also lets you access your phone book, even if your SIM card expires. While adding to the cost of a unit, in-built memory definitely extends the usability of the phone. More data that can be stored on such a phone helps in day to day use. Out of the 10 phones compared in this category, only the Nokia 3310, 3315 and Sony Ericsson T100 did not have in-built memory. The Sony Ericsson T200 can store 350 contacts, while the Alcatel 311, can store 250. The main



Alcatel OT 311
Rating: **B**
Price: Rs 4,995



Sony Ericsson T100
Rating: **A-**
Price: Rs 5,995

Top 5	Voice clarity (out of 5)	
	Nokia 2100	4
	Nokia 3310	4
	Nokia 3315	4
	Nokia 3350	4
	Nokia 3610	4